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THE SINO-AMERICAN LITTORAL WAR OF 2025

A Future History

More than two decades after the fact, the reasons why the United States and the People's Republic of China (PRC) avoided total war, let alone a nuclear exchange, during their armed conflict in the autumn of 2025 remain a source of dispute. What is clearer is why the Sino-American Littoral War broke out in the first place and the course it took. The result—the establishment of three geopolitical blocs in East Asia—continues to this day. The United States retained a rump alliance system, but the losses of Taiwan and the US alliance with South Korea were seen as major strategic defeats for Washington, leading to a tacit US withdrawal from the western Pacific. On the other hand, though seemingly victorious in the war, China's subsequent domination over a resentful bloc of allies and its broader diplomatic isolation narrowed the range of foreign policy initiatives that Beijing's military superiority should have made possible. The resulting cold war between the United States and China became the defining feature of geopolitics in the Asia-Pacific in the middle of the twenty-first century.

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